

Emma Dann

📍 Department of Genetics, Stanford University, Palo Alto, California 94305-5120 (USA)
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Education

PhD in Biological Sciences (Computational Biology) – University of Cambridge, UK (Oct 2019 – Oct 2023)

Advisors: Prof. Sarah Teichmann, Dr. John Marioni

Thesis title: *Discovering variation from cell atlases: comparative methods for single-cell genomics*

MSc in Cancer, Stem Cells and Developmental Biology (Bioinformatics profile) – Utrecht University, NL (Sep 2017 – Aug 2019)

BSc in Biomolecular Sciences and Technology – University of Trento, IT (Sep 2014 – Jul 2017)

Research experience

Post-doctoral fellow – **Stanford University**, Palo Alto, US (May 2024 – present)

Visiting post-doctoral fellow – **Gladstone Institute of Genomic Immunology**, San Francisco, US

Advisors: Prof. Jonathan Pritchard, Prof. Alex Marson

Graduate researcher – **Wellcome Sanger Institute**, Cambridge, UK (Oct 2019 – Jan 2024)

Advisors: Prof. Sarah Teichmann, Dr. John Marioni

Research intern – **European Molecular Biology Laboratory**, Heidelberg, DE (Sep 2018 – Aug 2019)

Advisors: Dr. Wolfgang Huber

Research intern – **KNAW Hubrecht Institute**, Utrecht, NL (Sep 2017 – Aug 2018)

Advisors: Prof. Alexander van Oudenaarden

Research intern – **Center for Integrative Biology**, University of Trento, IT (Feb 2017 – Jul 2017)

Advisors: Prof. Francesca Demichelis

Fellowships & awards

Fellowships

Helen Hay Whitney fellowship (Nov 2024 – present)

Postdoctoral fellowship, awarded \$229,500 over 3 years

European Molecular Biology Organization (EMBO) long-term fellowship (Jul 2024 - present)

Postdoctoral fellowship, awarded €130,800 over 2 years

Wellcome Sanger Institute PhD studentship, Wellcome Trust, UK (Oct 2019 - Oct 2023)

PhD fellowship, awarded £100,000 plus tuition over 4 years

U/Select honours programme Utrecht University, NL (Jan 2018 - Oct 2019)

Master's honors program, awarded €2,000 travel grant for international research internship

Merit Award University of Trento, IT (Oct 2017)

Prize for outstanding graduates, awarded €3,000

Funding

Anthropic AI for Science program (2026)

Awarded \$20,000 over 6 months

Contributed as key personnel to NIH R01 grant (2R01HG008140) (2025)

PIs: Jonathan K. Pritchard, Alex Marson

Reviewed as 1st percentile score

Contributed as key personnel to ERC Advanced Grant (ThyDESIGN) (2022)

PI: Sarah Teichmann

Awarded €2.5M over 5 years

Other awards

Tahoe Deep Dive Hackathon, first prize winner (May 2025)

Awarded \$20,000 for best project on prediction of clinical outcomes from large-scale drug perturbation datasets.

Publications

► denotes manuscripts as leading author, * denotes equal contribution

Peer-reviewed Manuscripts

► Zhu R.*, **Dann E.***, Yan J., Retana J.R., Goto R., Guitche R., Brix L., ... , Pritchard J.K., Marson A. (2026) Genome-scale perturb-seq in primary human CD4+ T cells maps context-specific regulators of T cell programs and human immune traits. *Cell* | [Full text](#) | [code](#) | [data](#)

Jung H., Devant P., Ching C., Ota M., **Dann E.**, Zhu R., Modak C., ... , Marson A., Carnevale J. (2026) Virus-like particles enable targeted gene engineering and pooled CRISPR screening in primary human myeloid cells. *Nature Biotechnology* | [Full text](#)

Liu Q., Chen P.A., Urs E., ... , **Dann E.**, Modak C., ... , Marson A., Carnevale J. (2026) *In vivo* genome-wide CRISPR screens in human T cells to enhance T cell therapy for solid tumors. *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Rathore U., Dugan E., Thornton H., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Marson A. (2026) Systematic discovery of pro- and anti-HIV host factors in primary human CD4+ T cells. *Cell* | [Full text](#)

Deconinck L., Zappia L., Cannoodt R., Morgan M., **scverse core**, ... , Saeys Y. (2025) *anndataR* improves interoperability between R and Python in single-cell transcriptomics. *Bioinformatics* | [Full text](#)

Heumos L., Ji Y., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Theis F.J. (2025) Pertpy: an end-to-end framework for perturbation analysis. *Nature Methods* | [Full text](#) | [python package](#)

Ota M., Spence J.P., Zeng T., **Dann E.**, Milind N., Marson A., Pritchard J.K. (2025) Causal modeling of gene effects from regulators to programs to traits: integration of genetic associations and Perturb-seq. *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Luecken M., Gigante S., Burkhardt D., Cannoodt R., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Saeys Y., Theis F.J., Krishnaswamy S. (2025) Defining and benchmarking open problems in single-cell analysis. *Nature Biotechnology* | [Full text](#)

Schuster V., **Dann E.**, Krogh A., Teichmann S.A. (2024) multiDGD: A versatile deep generative model for multi-omics data. *Nature Communications* | [Full text](#) | [python package](#)

Yayon N., Kedlian V., Boehme L., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Uhlmann V., Notarangelo L.D., Germain R.N., Radtke A.J., Marioni J.C., Taghon T., Teichmann S.A. (2024) A spatial human thymus cell atlas mapped to a continuous tissue axis. *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Oliver A.J., Ni H., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Elmentaite R., Teichmann S.A. (2024) Single-cell integration reveals metaplasia in inflammatory gut diseases. *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Missarova A., **Dann E.**, ... , Marioni J.C. (2023) Leveraging neighborhood representations of single-cell data to achieve sensitive DE testing with miloDE. *Genome Biology* | [Full text](#) | [R package](#)

Sumanaweera D., Suo C., Muraro D., **Dann E.**, ... , Teichmann S.A. (2023) Gene-level alignment of single cell trajectories. *Nature Methods* | [Full text](#) | [python package](#)

Barnes J. L., He P., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Teichmann S.A., Meyer K. B., Nikolic M. Z. (2023) Early human lung immune cell development and its role in epithelial cell fate. *Science Immunology* | [Full text](#)

► **Dann E.**, Cujba A.M., Oliver A., Meyer K., Teichmann S.A., Marioni J.C. (2023) Precise identification of cell states altered in disease using healthy single-cell references, *Nature Genetics* | [Full text](#) | [code](#) | [python package](#)

Botting R.A., Goh I., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Teichmann S.A. , Haniffa M. (2023) Yolk sac cell atlas reveals multiorgan functions during human early development. *Science* | [Full text](#)

Suo C., Polanski K., **Dann E.**, ... , Tuong Z.K., Clatworthy M., Teichmann S.A. (2023) Dandelion uses the single-cell adaptive immune receptor repertoire to explore lymphocyte developmental origins, *Nature Biotechnology* | [Full text](#) | [python package](#)

Heumos L., ... **Single-cell Best Practices Consortium**, ... , Theis F.J. (2023) Best practices for single-cell analysis across modalities. *Nature Reviews Genetics* | [Full text](#)

► Suo C.*, **Dann E.***, ... , Haniffa M., Teichmann S.A. (2022) Mapping the developing human immune system across organs. *Science* | [Full text](#) | [code](#) | [data](#)

► Lalchand V.*, Ravuri A.*, **Dann E.***, ..., Madad S., Teichmann S.A., Lawrence N.D. (2022) Modelling Technical and Biological Effects in scRNA-seq data with Scalable GPLVMs. *Proceedings of the 17th Machine Learning in Computational Biology meeting* | [Full text](#)

He P., Lim K., Sun D., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Meyer K.B., Rawlins E.L. (2022) A human fetal lung cell atlas uncovers proximal-distal gradients of differentiation and key regulators of epithelial fates, *Cell* | [Full text](#)

Kleshchevnikov V., Shmatko A., **Dann E.**, ... , Stegle O., Bayraktar O.A. (2022) Cell2location maps fine-grained cell types in spatial transcriptomics. *Nature Biotechnology* | [Full text](#) | [python package](#)

► **Dann E.**, Henderson N.C., Teichmann S.A., Morgan M.D., Marioni J.C. (2022) Differential abundance testing on single-cell data using k-nearest neighbor graphs, *Nature Biotechnology* | [Full text](#) | [R package](#) | [python package](#)

Jardine L., Webb S., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Göttgens B., Roberts I., Teichmann S. and Haniffa M. (2021) Blood and immune development in human fetal bone marrow and Down syndrome, *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Elmentaite R., Kumasaka N., Roberts K., Fleming A., **Dann E.**, ... , James K.R., Teichmann S.A. (2021), Cells of the human intestinal tract mapped across space and time, *Nature* | [Full text](#)

Stephenson E., Reynolds G., Botting R.A., Calero-Nieto F.J., Morgan M.D., Tuong Z.K., Bach K., Sunnak W., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Duncan C.J.A, Smith K., Teichmann S.A., Clatworthy M.R., Marioni J.C., Gottgens B., Haniffa M. (2020) Single-cell multi-omics analysis of the immune response in COVID-19, *Nature Medicine* | [Full text](#)

Beltran H., Romanel A., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Benelli M., and Demichelis F. (2020) Circulating Tumor DNA Profile Recognizes Transformation to Castration-Resistant Neuroendocrine Prostate Cancer, *Journal of Clinical Investigation* | [Full text](#)

Pre-print Manuscripts

Hartman A, Blair J., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Satpathy A., Roth T. (2026) Systematic identification of seed-driven off-target effects in Perturb-seq experiments. *bioRxiv* | [Full text](#)

Pett J.P., Prete M., Pham D., England N., ... , **Dann E.**, ... , Teichmann S.A., Meyer K. (2025) An atlas of TF driven gene programs across human cells. *bioRxiv* | [Full text](#)

► **Dann E.***, Teeple E.*, Elmentaite R., ... , Rinaldis E., Teichmann S.A. (2024) Estimating the impact of single-cell RNA sequencing of human tissues on drug target validation., *medRxiv* | [Full text](#) | [code](#)

Presentations

Conference oral presentations

June 2026 - Biology at Scale conference, Wellcome Genome Campus, Hinxton (UK)

May 2026 - Warren Alpert Computational Biology and AI Research Symposium, Stanford (US)

Feb 2026 - Arc Institute Symposium, San Francisco (US)

Apr 2025 - Chan Zuckerberg Initiative Cell Science Meeting, Chicago (US)

Nov 2022 - Machine Learning in Computational Biology conference, virtual

Jun 2022 - Single Cell Biology conference, Wellcome Genome Campus, Hinxton (UK)

May 2022 - The Biology of Genomes, Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory (US)

Oct 2021 - Chan Zuckerberg Initiative Single Cell Biology Meeting, virtual
Sep 2021 - Next Generation Genomics Meeting, virtual
Mar 2021 - CZI Seed Networks Computational biology meeting, virtual

Invited research seminars

Apr 2026 - Emerging Genomic Scientists Symposium, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia (US)
Oct 2025 - Ultima Genomics user group session @ American Society for Human Genetics, Boston (US)
Sep 2025 - scverse community meeting, virtual
Jul 2025 - AI + Biomedicine seminar, Stanford (US)
Sep 2024 - BRAID Genentech, South San Francisco (US)
Sep 2024 - Human Genetics department, University of Chicago, Chicago (US)
Sep 2024 - SQLIFTS Lecture Series, Northwestern University, Chicago (US)
Mar 2024 - Human Technopole, Milan (IT)
Dec 2023 - Google DeepMind, London (UK)
Jul 2023 - Sanofi Precision Medicine & Computational biology, Cambridge (US)
Jun 2023 - Chan Zuckerberg Initiative, Redwood City (US)
Apr 2023 - Cambridge AI club for biomedicine, Milner Institute, Cambridge (UK)
Dec 2022 - UMC Utrecht single-cell genomics meeting, virtual
Sep 2022 - UK Conference of Bioinformatics and Computational Biology, virtual
Jul 2022 - Computational Health Center seminar, Helmholtz Munich (DE)
Apr 2022 - Maxwell Society Annual Conference, King's College London (UK)
Apr 2022 - NYU Langone single cell journal club, virtual
Mar 2021 - Cambridge Center for Physical Biology Single Cell Symposium, virtual

Guest lectures

Aug 2024 - Why there's never been a better time to study human biology, [Girls in Research](#) program (virtual)
Aug 2023 - Intro to single-cell genomics series, University of Sri Jayewardenepura (virtual)
Mar 2023 - Introduction to multiomics data integration and visualisation, EMBL-EBI training course (UK)
Apr 2022 - Best practices and open challenges in single-cell genomics data analysis, Maxwell Society Annual Conference, King's College London (UK)

Conference poster presentations

Oct 2025 - American Society for Human Genetics conference, Boston (US)
Jul 2023 - Human Cell Atlas General Meeting, Toronto (CA)
Oct 2022 - Single Cell Genomics conference, Utrecht (NL)
Jun 2021 - Human Cell Atlas General Meeting, virtual

Teaching & mentoring

Computational research assistant recruitment and mentoring, Marson lab (Fall 2025 - present)

PhD rotation student recruitment and mentoring, Pritchard lab (Winter 2025 - present)

Stanford & Tanzania Human Genetics Organization virtual training program (Spring 2025)
One-on-one virtual mentoring program on research project for students from Tanzania

PhD rotation student recruitment and mentoring, Teichmann lab (Fall 2021 - Fall 2023)

Systems biology: From large datasets to biological insight, EMBL-EBI training course (Jul 2022)
Invited instructor for single-cell multi-omics module ([course material](#))

Advanced topics in Single Cell Genomics, Swiss Institute for Bioinformatics course (Apr 2022)
Invited instructor for multi-omics module ([course material](#))

Advanced topics in Single Cell Genomics, SciLifeLab / Swiss Institute for Bioinformatics Summer School (Aug 2021)
Invited instructor for multi-omics module ([course material](#))

Leadership & outreach

Core team member, [scverse consortium](#) (Feb 2024 – present)

I am part of the governance team of the consortium, overseeing the development and maintenance of foundational software tools for omics data analysis.

- Organizational governance and strategic planning
- Development of academic and industry partnerships for funding initiatives and collaborative research projects
- Lead organizer of the [scverse annual conference](#) and [community hackathons](#)
- Contributor to open-source [tutorials](#) and [resources](#) for newcomers to single-cell genomics analysis in python

Competition judge, [Open Problems Single-cell perturbations Kaggle competition](#) (Fall 2023)

Served as judge for NeurIPS-affiliated machine learning challenge focused on predicting drug perturbation responses.

Co-organizer, [Strengthening integration pipelines session, Human Cell Atlas general meeting](#) (Jul 2023)

Co-organized and led panel discussion on cell atlas construction and usage.

Member of the selection panel, [Sanger prize competition](#) (Mar 2023)

The Sanger Prize competition funds research internships at Sanger for undergraduate students from LMI countries. I was a member of the Grad Panel, evaluating essays from applicants.

Co-organizer [Open Problems in Single-Cell Analysis Jamboree](#) (April 2021)

Led task for benchmarking of compositional analysis methods for scRNA-seq.

Co-organizer, [EBI-Sanger-Cambridge PhD Symposium](#) (Feb 2020)

I was in charge of the scientific program and sponsorship for the PhD program symposium.

Board member, [Open Wet Lab \(OWL\)](#) (Oct 2015 – Jan 2018)

OWL is the first biohacking organization in Italy. I was in charge of the association's budget and directed the publication of OWL's blog and scientific outreach articles for local newspapers.

Peer review

Journals: Nature (1 paper), Cell (1* paper), Nature Biotechnology (2* papers), Nature Genetics (1 paper), Nature Communications (1 paper), Genome Biology (1 paper), Bioinformatics Advances (1 paper), OUP Bioinformatics (1 paper), Reviewer Commons (1 paper)

*Assisting a senior reviewer

Conferences: Machine Learning in Computational Biology (2023, 2024, 2026)

Grants/fellowships: Chan Zuckerberg Initiative Single Cell Biology Data Insights, Christian Doppler Research Association Transfer.S2S grants

Software

pertpy |  [scverse/pertpy](#) | contributor | perturbation analysis toolkit for the scverse ecosystem.

miloR |  [MarioniLab/miloR](#) | primary developer | R/Bioconductor package for the identification of differential cell abundance in KNN graphs for single-cell data

milopy |  [emdann/milopy](#) | primary developer | python package for the identification of differential cell abundance in KNN graphs for single-cell data

genomic-features |  [scverse/genomic-features](#) | primary developer | Genomic annotations using Bioconductor resources in Python.

oor_benchmark |  [MarioniLab/oor_benchmark](#) | primary developer | python framework to benchmark workflows for detection of out-of-reference cells in comparative single-cell analysis

cell2location |  [BayraktarLab/cell2location](#) | contributor | python package for mapping of tissue cell types via integration of single cell RNA-seq and spatial transcriptomics data

Industry experience

Data science consultant – Ensocell Ltd (Oct 2023 – Mar 2024)

Target discovery platform and analysis of single-cell data